

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, April 26, 2017, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Assistant Mayor Bergeron at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

Ward I Councilor Carolyn Towle
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope
At-Large Councilor Keith Raymond
Assistant Mayor Victor Bergeron
At-Large Councilor Allen Damren
At-Large Councilor Bruce Temple
Ward III Councilor Nicholas Koloski
At-Large Councilor John Simonds

Absent:

Mayor Charlene Lovett

Also present were:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager
Jane Taylor, City Solicitor

AGENDA CHANGES

None

MAYOR'S NOTES

Mr. Damren talked about the Steppin' Up to End Violence Walk and asked that if Councilors wanted to be on a team or to donate, they should contact him. Last year five Councilors participated in the walk.

Mr. Bergeron read a list of notes that Mayor Lovett had given him: Thanks to all who have participated in the cleanup initiatives. The week of May 1st Public Works will be picking up leaves around the City. Due to the weather, Stevens High School (SHS) students will cleanup a number of the parks and a portion of the Bobby Woodman Trail in May. The Memorial Day Parade will take place on May 29th and two families will be honored who lost family members during the Vietnam War. The Council and School Board will hold a joint meeting on June 22nd, 6 p.m. at the Sugar River Valley Regional Technical Center.

Mr. McNutt referred to an email from Parks and Recreation Director Mark Brislin regarding the cutting down of two trees in Broad Street Park. The trees were dead. Log Cabin Nursery will grind the stumps. The trees will be replaced April 28th, Arbor Day. Eversource will plant two trees in the Park and one tree at the Library. On that day, people may speak with the arborist regarding the kinds of trees to plant near power lines. Eversource will also pass out seedlings to celebrate Arbor Day.

Mr. McNutt thanked the School Board for its contribution of \$11,787 to go toward resurfacing the Monadnock Park track. The schools use the track.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

Bernie Folta, Ward 3, this year is an election year in Claremont (Tuesday, November 7th) and all nine Councilors are up for election.

NEW BUSINESS

Southwestern Community Services Transportation Update

Keith Thibault, Southwestern Community Services (SWCS), said the Sullivan County Transportation Program has been in service for six months. Many good things have happened. The volunteer driver program is up and running, and the bus driver program is up and running. The first two quarters have been successful. They are working out of a Charlestown Road location. All former drivers were rehired, some moved on and have been replaced. They are fully staffed with drivers. Representative John Cloutier sponsored a couple of bills, one was a call for more federal funding for small rural transit programs and the other was a request for state funding of small rural transit programs.

Mr. Thibault said the biggest highlight was that they hired a very experienced transit manager, Terri Paige, from NHDOT.

Terri Paige said since October, all policies and procedures have been in place. This was an aged fleet. All vehicles have been inspected. They have received two new buses and a third one is expected in May with another one in the fall. They have an MOU (Memorandum of Understanding) signed with Turning Points Network so that their participants can use the bus. The County Complex inmates use the bus for job searches. They are working with SHS to transport students to the college. The numbers for Claremont are good; Newport and Charlestown are down. The Day Out Program in Charlestown is closed. They will look at those two routes for restructuring to increase ridership. They are looking at routes and stops to enhance the service.

Mr. Thibault said the goal is to expand and augment economic development aspects. They want to help commerce in Claremont and to help employers. They are working with Joel Schneid, Sugar River Valley Regional Technical Center, to help get students get out into employment situations.

Mr. Thibault said last year Claremont donated \$22,500, pro-rated. They've applied to Sullivan County for \$50,000. Charlestown has approved \$14,000. Newport was asked to double its donation to \$10,000; the vote will be May 9th. Preservation of Affordable Housing donated \$2,500. Sugar River Apartments are a stop on the route. SWCS recertified to give Medicaid rides. They've met with representatives of DHMC in Lebanon and made a request for \$10,000. The Newport Service Organization gave them \$2,500. They are trying to generate revenue from each of the stops (Adopt-a-Stop Program). They still need assistance from communities. They are asking Claremont to provide \$30,000 for the program next year. The only way to get federal funding is to have the local match.

River Valley Community College – Dr. Ali Rafieymehr

Dr. Ali Rafieymehr, Interim President and Vice President of Academics Affairs at River Valley Community College, said he will be the Interim President for the next two years. Twenty states are involved in an initiative called Guided Pathway which is sponsored by Complete College America. It takes students an average of 3.5 years to graduate a 2-year program. The programs should be 60 credits; most are over 70 credits, which they shouldn't be. 15 to Finish is a program to encourage students to take 15 credits per semester. Purpose First is to start exposing students in their first semester to different businesses around the state/city. Program mapping will make it clear what classes students need to take and when they need to take them. RVCC has been approved for two new programs that will start this fall, Information Technology and Computer Science & Global Innovation. Both are needed by the state and city. They also have a new certificate, Infant & Toddlers, which will start in the fall.

Running Start is a program where high school students take courses that are taught by teachers who are qualified to teach college courses and the student gets college credit.

Catch the Wave was renamed Bridge to College and the class fee of \$250 will increase to \$300.

Pathway to Success is a collaboration between SHS, Claremont Middle School and RVCC. Twenty students are selected to start taking college courses over four years. The cost for 20 students over four years is \$160,000. Donations are supporting the program. Students don't pay. The major to start is Information Technology. May 9th, 6 p.m. at RVCC, 80-100 8th graders will hear about this program.

Workforce development is important to RVCC and the community. They are working with Canam and Hypertherm to find out what they need.

Graduation is May 19th and the keynote speaker is Senator Maggie Hassan.

Ms. Towle said about three years ago, she wanted to go back to work and wanted to do something different. She needed Microsoft Excel and Word training and there was no facilitation for someone to learn a new career in this age bracket and that is an issue. Mr.

Rafieymehr said they offered a class in Lebanon and they can look at offering it in Claremont as well.

Current Use Update

Marlene Jordan, Assessor, said the 2017 proposed values have gone up from 2016. They go up and down with the economy. Her department is looking at all of the Current Use files and are about one-third the way through.

Mr. Temple asked about the stewardship range. Ms. Jordan said Claremont is at the midpoint or above. Mr. Temple asked what it would take to look for more. Ms. Jordan said she can look to see what the process is. Seventy percent of the City's land is in Current Use. \$27,739,000 is the ad valorem value and the Current Use value is \$1.1 million. She said the majority of communities are midrange or slightly above. She can check to see what the process is to increase the value.

Mr. Temple said the City received \$47,000 in revenue from properties that are in Current Use and the public needs to be aware of that.

Mary Walter, Finance Director, said she did a survey a couple of years ago. Salem has 2% of its land in Current Use and Colebrook has 75%. Many communities are on a par with Claremont.

Mr. McNutt believes Claremont has the size and infrastructure to have more people than it currently has. The ability to have enough housing is a challenge. He sat down with the economic development team to discuss where to put in a new residential development and they struggled to be able to put together enough property for 100 acres with water/sewer access. We want to maintain a good amount of land in Current Use for recreation and conservation. Right now there is an inhibition to creating the conditions for that development because of its tax status. He is shocked that in a community the size of Claremont, that the actual land area for residential development is less than 200 acres.

There was a discussion about getting water and sewer to developments. It might take a developer a year to get permitted for a well. For sewers, there are options.

Ms. Taylor said the primary goal for Current Use was preservation of farmland. She suggested showing how many acres/percentages are in each category.

Mr. Koloski said the Conservation Commission's Natural Resources Inventory may be helpful.

Mr. Temple talked about development on Charlestown Road and Grissom Lane. The area is beautiful. There is water there and the sanitary sewer with pump station is only at 25% capacity. He suggested someone may want to revisit that area to see if the City wants it to stay industrial. We need tax revenue going forward.

Mr. McNutt thinks Mr. Temple has a great point. In Claremont we have upwards of 500 manufacturing jobs that could be filled. The issue is that we don't necessarily have the workforce to meet that demand. If we could build housing in those areas, we may be able to bring people in to fill those jobs.

Mr. Pope agreed with Mr. Temple. Those are desirable areas

Bernie Folta, Ward 3, said one issue in Claremont is some people believe that if you build more workforce housing, that will attract people with children and that will add to the burden of the schools. Although that is not necessarily true. He said land use and housing is being worked on by the Master Plan subcommittee. Draft chapters of the Master Plan are starting to go to the Planning Board. On Current Use, he suggested making a range dependent on the assessment of the property. If it is higher quality, the local assessor could make an adjustment

Mr. Temple said regarding students, Claremont graduates half the number it used to

Mr. Pope said there needs to be a discussion about workforce housing, not subsidized housing. When he had kids at home, he spent more money in town. People need to quit thinking of young people as liabilities. Talk about elderly, those kids will be the ones to support those generations. We are not growing industry because we are not growing our workforce.

Mr. Pope said regarding increased school expenses, the buildings have fixed costs regardless of the number of kids in them.

Ratification of Union Contracts

Mr. McNutt had sent the Council a draft of Public Works' contract. He thanked Public Works employees for coming to the table with open minds. Two major tenets is this is a one-year contract and there will be no cost of living increases. They approved raising the health care percentage for new employees. Current Public Works employees pay 10%, all new employees will pay 20% and the City will pay the rest.

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Mr. Simonds to approve a Collective Bargaining Agreement between the City of Claremont and AFSCME Council 93, Local 1348 (Public Works Union), which calls for the following increases in salary and benefits:

<u>Year</u>	<u>Estimated Increase (Salary & Benefits)</u>
2017	\$0

Said sums represent the additional costs attributable to the increase in salaries and benefits over those funds appropriated at current staffing levels. Because there is no increase in

salary or benefits under the Agreement for fiscal year 2017, there is no additional impact on the tax rate for the current budget.

The City Council further authorizes the city manager, or his designees, to take such actions as may be necessary to implement this motion.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Mr. Pope said last month he received a letter from Wayne MacElreavy, Chair of the Claremont Historical Society, regarding artifacts of the City and Mr. Pope thinks it would be good to have Mr. MacElreavy be a part of the discussion.

Mr. Pope said he would like to have workforce housing as an agenda item. Getting young people and workforce into Claremont would help our economic development.

Mr. McNutt said regarding Mr. Pope's request for workforce housing, that the week of May 15th, at the Claremont Senior Center, he is personally sponsoring a presentation by two people who have spent their careers doing workforce housing. Ted Carman, Concord Square Planning and Development and his legislative partner, Eleanor White. They have written some legislation that was passed in Massachusetts that is a program to incentivize development of workforce housing. They are trying to get this legislation passed in all six New England states. They will give a talk about what the workforce housing trust fund bill encompasses.

Ms. Towle would like an update on the JSL building, smokestack on the river, Sugar River Drive house and a new date for a tour of the CSB Community Center.

Mr. Koloski said a long time ago, when Deborah Cutts was Mayor, the City held a job fair. He would like to see the City sponsor another job fair. Ms. Taylor said several job fairs have been held in conjunction with RVCC. He said he texted with Alex Ray of the Common Man and was told we could use the ballroom at no charge. He has seen on social media that a lot of people are saying there are no jobs in this area. He thinks it would send a nice message if this were done under the auspices of the City.

Mr. Pope said it would be good for the school district and the City to work together on this.

Mr. Temple said he would be anxious to hear more about workforce housing, such as the definition. Regarding real estate, there are a lot of homes for sale, but people who are coming in can't buy the homes with the wages they will earn or the taxes are too high.

Mr. Temple said one thing he wants to see before the budget discussion is a discussion of the cost recovery at the CSB Community Center. He asked, of all programming Mr. Brislin is charged with, what percent is actually covered by fees. He would like to look at what is

provided versus the fees that are charged. The City doesn't bring in anywhere near enough to support the Library, yet we provide that service.

Mr. Damren said he is the one who requested a tour of the community center to see what are the maintenance issues that aren't being addressed. He knows the handicap doors don't always close tightly. Those items need to be looked at because he believes Council will be asked to add a maintenance position.

Mr. Koloski said two people had previously come forward, Mr. Limoges mentioned blinds in the Police Department and also someone brought forward a concern regarding a "window opening" going up the stairs to the opera house. Mr. McNutt said there is money in the Police budget to purchase blinds. He doesn't know about the Opera House

Mr. Bergeron brought up the budget meetings. He said these will be work meetings for the Council only and the public will not be invited to speak. He said the public hearing will be set for a future date.

After lengthy discussion, there was a consensus of the Council to hold Budget Meetings on May 11, 18 and 24, 6:30 p.m. to 10 p.m. The Public Hearing will be in June. These meetings are for the budget only, unless there is an emergency.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

ADJOURNMENT

At 8:29 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. Pope and seconded by Mr. Simonds to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 8-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council